Chapter 5
Strategically Communicating the Message

Quotes

"I was asked to write a book but did not have enough time, so I wrote two."
Mark Twain

"The most valuable of all talents is that of never using two words when one will do."
Thomas Jefferson

Communicating the Story

Although this chapter focuses on communicating the story with a slide deck presentation, the "Content" applies to all vehicles that could be used to convey the story to a senior executive. A slide deck was chosen to detail the use of "Content" because currently it is the vehicle of choice when formally communicating with senior executives. However, given "Content" creation is not specifically tied to the delivery vehicle, it is conveyed without reference to utilizing a slide deck. The section following "Content", will add the slide deck viewpoint: "Content: Story and Details from a Slide Deck Perspective".

Writing does not come easy; it requires rigor and focus. Every communication has a different set of parameters that require content based on the audience and situation. Consider that a presentation on Analytics would need to be fundamentally different if presented to CxOs (e.g. CEO, COO, CFO), your data science colleagues, high school students or toddlers. However, there is nothing special about an analytics message as compared to a finance message or a manufacturing message – the content is developed based on the parameters of the situation. The development of material for the communication must focus on what is relevant and important within the situation. If the author focuses only on what they want to say and not on the Content, they will likely not get the response expected.

Content

There are three dimensions that drive the content: context, story and details.

	Description	**Relevance**
Context	Understanding the situation in which the communication is going to be delivered	Increases probability that the audience is receptive and the message is well-received
Story	Take key objectives and translate them into a logical flow; this is often called the **Storyline or Horizontal Logic:** titles from each page can be compiled with the resulting text being the "story"	Focuses the output on a message that is rich, clear, relevant, and compelling
Details	Breaking the storyline into simple and effective modules with details.	Communicates complex messages logically, concisely and effectively

Context

As you develop content, you need to consider the context of the audience and situation. The following list details considerations for the context of the presentation.

- **Desired outcome:** Buy in, understanding, urgency, faith
- **Seniority:** Core team members, management team, engineers, CIO
- **Power dynamics:** Alone, direct reports, peers, customers, bosses
- **Number:** 1, 3, 8, 120 attendees
- **Location:** Conference call, open office, hotel, board room, hallway
- **Occasion:** Introduction, proposal, kick-off, training, readout, final presentation
- **Style and culture:** Direct, analytical, hierarchical, risk averse, self-discovery
- **Language:** Taboos, terminology, politics, trusting, references
- **Duration:** 15 minutes, one hour, all day

In some cases, the context may involve multiple answers to the context questions. In which case, you need to determine which is the primary context. For example, you may be speaking to broad audience of employees including senior executives. You will need to determine the seniority on which you're focusing the presentation. In this case, the communication is likely focused on the broader employee population. Senior executive would have received a communication specifically to their level of seniority. However, in any case, the senior executive should be aware of the communication's seniority focus.

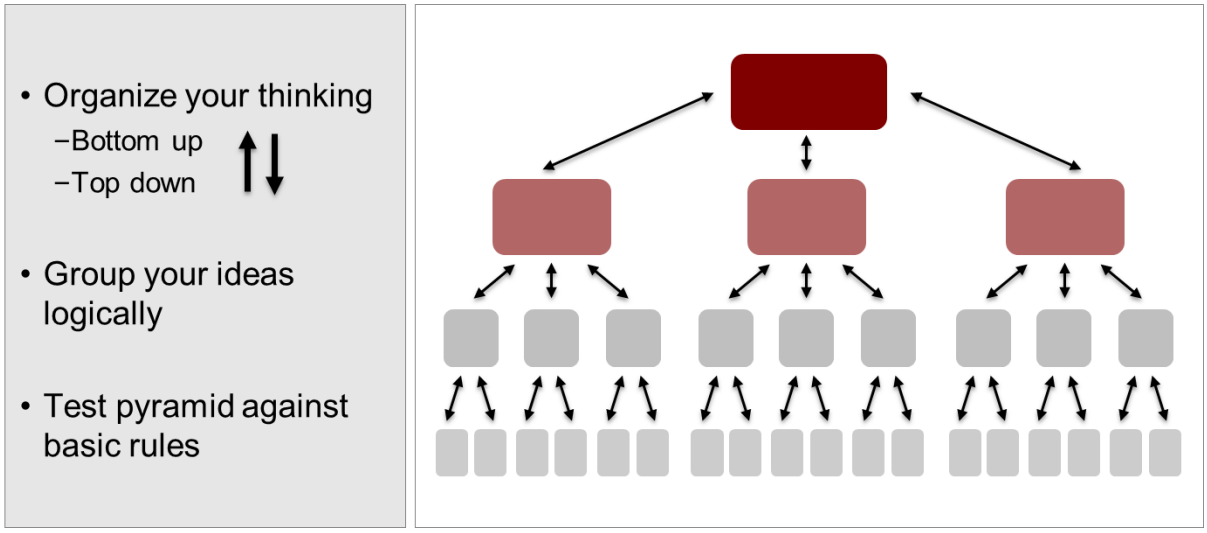
Story

In order to develop content, you have to know what you want to say…you have to have a story!

Story Guidelines:

- Identify the objectives of the communication
- State all the key messages to be delivered
- Categorize messages into groups
- Organize the groups and messages into a simple and logical flow

You should be able to "pyramid" the details of your story to identify the key components



The Pyramid Principle drives storyline and slide structure
Source: Barbara Minto, The Minto Pyramid Principle, http://www.barbaraminto.com

Details

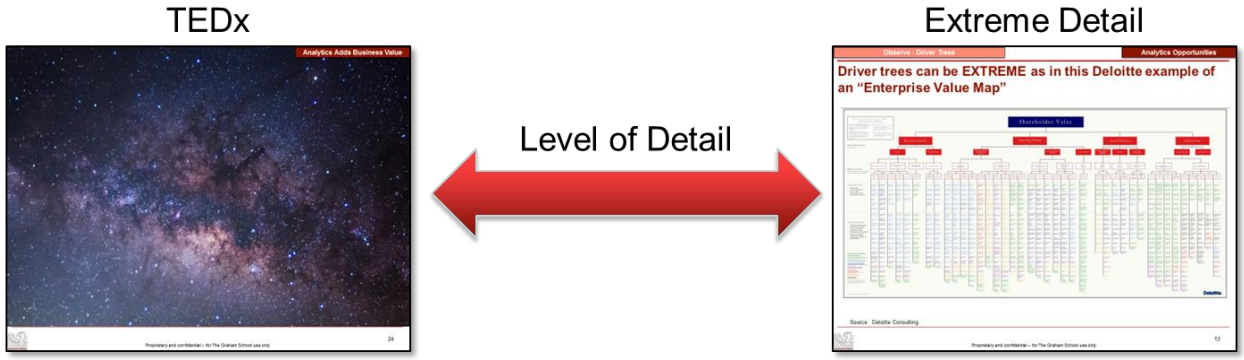
For every message, there are details. If the message is about US Markets, the details on the message should be about US Markets.

The details of your story should contain enough information, but no more. Do not forget that you know the information in-depth, but your audience does not:

- Ensure you don't leave out key information that the audience needs in order to draw conclusions
- Stick to the facts: all your conclusions need to be supported by facts
- Present the communication to someone who knows nothing about the issue to see if it is clear and complete

Content: Story and Details from a Slide Deck Perspective

Every presentation has a different set of parameters that require content based on the audience and situation. Consider that a presentation on Analytics would need to be fundamentally different if presented to CxOs (e.g. CEO, COO, CFO), your data science colleagues or high school students.



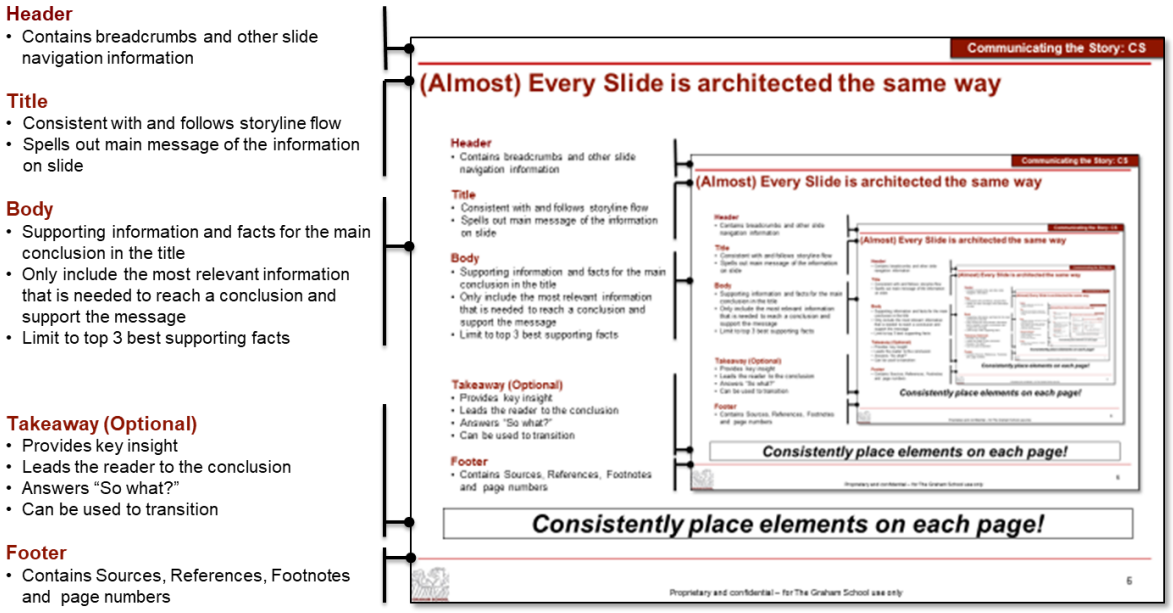
Week 1: "N Dimensional Space"
Week 4: Deloitte Driver Tree

For CxOs neither one of the above extremes are typically relevant. A CxO presentation must stand on its own – it must be able to communicate the content without a voice over. This becomes evident in all the following typical situations.

- You start your presentation and the CxO notices an agenda item that's of interest and you spend most of the time in the meeting answering questions about the topic which are unrelated to the material you want to present.
- "Sorry, I'm 10 minutes late…important meeting, and I need to leave 10 minutes early for another important meeting." You now have 10 minutes to cover material from a 30-minute deck. You'll need to pick and choose what you discuss and count on the deck to provide information on the remaining material.
- "Sorry, something has come up, can you walk me to the elevator and provide me the highlights? "
- "Sorry, the CFO sends his regrets. I'll give her a copy of the deck."

However, even though the deck stands on its own, it does not mean that the presenter simply reads the slides to the audience. How to present persuasively is detailed in Chapter 7.

In order to make it easier for you audience to understand your material, you need to architect the material to make it as easy to understand as possible. A key approach to doing that is to utilize your firm's template. This makes it easy for the audience to know where to look for key structural components within the deck. Beyond leveraging the template, make sure that you consistently place items on each slide. The following diagram illustrates a slide architecture that should be used consistently throughout your slides.



Placing key structural components in the same place on each slide, does not mean you can't have variety across slides. Typically, the variety will come in the body of the slide. You can use graphics, text and combinations of both to communicate the message appropriately.

Building a slide deck follows a similar process to writing a paper and the quip, “Proper Planning and Preparation Prevents Poor Performance!” is an important consideration.

- Plan
  - Story. What do I want to say?
  - Storyboard. How am I going to say it?
- Write
  - Slides. How am I going to show it?

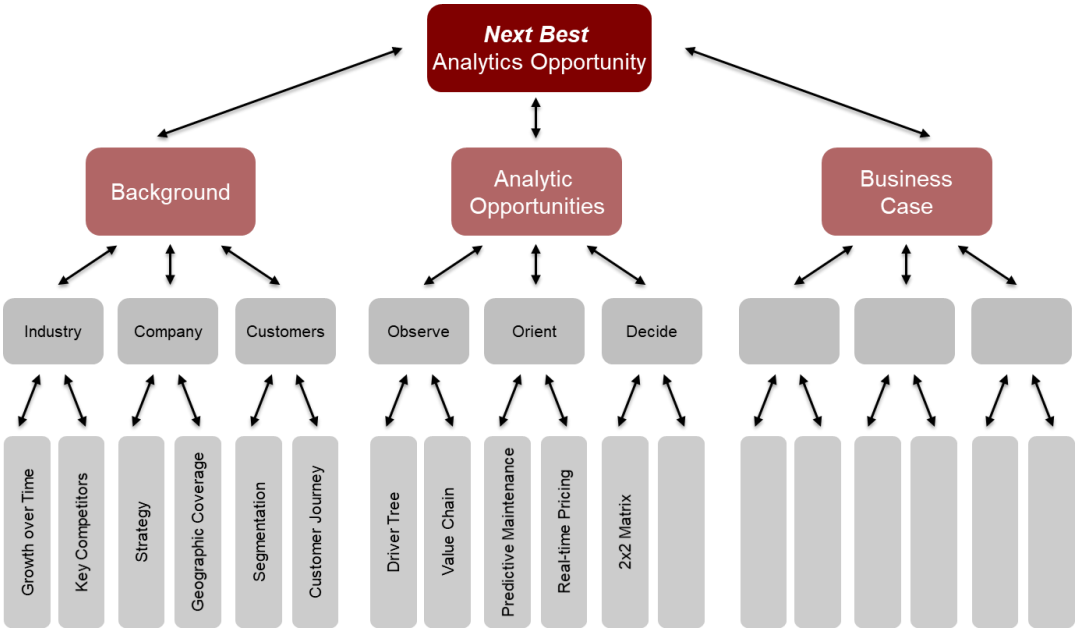
There are multiple tools available to deliver slides to an audience:

- Microsoft PowerPoint
- Google Slides
- Prezi
- Apple Keynote

Each of these tools has advantages and disadvantages. In most cases the choice of presentation tool is determined by your organization’s environment.

In the following sections we will explore creating a slide deck through the content, structure and style that are required. Our focus will be on creating the slide deck for a senior executive audience.

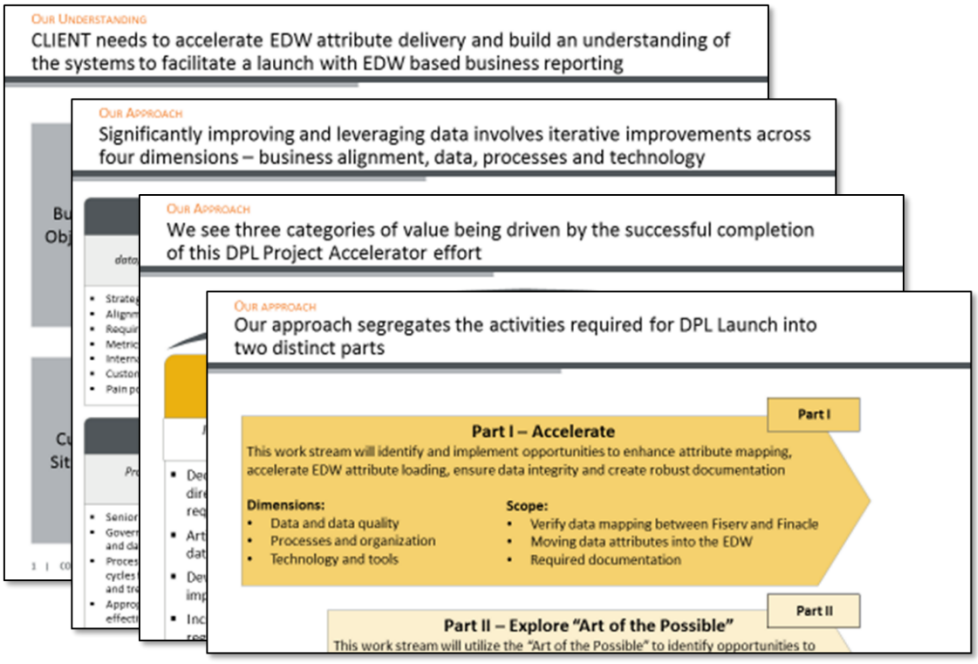
If we look at an example pyramid for a slide deck on identifying “The Next Best Analytics Opportunity,” we can see how the pyramid concept can be used to structure a presentation. Remember that you can start at the top or at the bottom, but ultimately the pyramid must be complete.



Pyramid for “Next Best Analytics Opportunity”

When we look at each slide of the presentation, the titles should tell a story – there should be ***Horizontal Logic***. Every slide should represent a piece of the story. By connecting the titles from every

slide either in a document, or by reading them, you should complete a cohesive and clear story. If putting the titles together does NOT tell your story, then you need to work on the flow.



The story translates key questions, objectives, answers, recommendations, and supporting analysis into a logical flow. In creating the story remember:

- **Clear, consistent theme:** One master theme supported across slides
- **Natural flow:** Story transitions across pages
- **Finite takeaways:** Specific messages designed to engage client(s)
- **Compelling:** Use the Pyramid Principle to structure the materials
- **Inductive reasoning:** Tell client up front what you are going to tell them
- **Horizontal logic / Storyline:** Logic consistent across slides
- **Concise:** Presentation length appropriate to story

For every slide, the details, the optional takeaway and the storyline title support their part of the story. This Vertical Logic means there are no inconsistencies between those three components. If the title is about US Markets, the details on the slide should be about US Markets and the takeaway, if there, is a key point to remember about US Markets.



Vertical Logic provides each slide with one clear message

As stated previously, the slide, especially for senior executives, must stand on its own…no voiceover required. But you must focus on not being redundant. Focus on your message:

- Do not include slides that fall outside your flow just because they look nice or you worked hard to obtain the information
- Say each idea once. Choose the key issues and do not repeat unnecessarily. Do not repeat the same thing with different words
- Your biggest obstacle is that you know too much: remember the phrase, "less is more."

Good slides communicate one clear message in a compelling way in support of the overall storyline. Each slide presents information that supports the message of the slide:

- Vertical logic: Logic consistent from header to supporting body text – Title, text and Takeaway support 1 message
- Rich data: Charts, graphs, tables, anecdotes, photos, quotes
- Visually appealing: Pleasant look and feel
- Varied visuals: Mixed visual layouts across slides (not repetitive)
- Legible: Could be read by someone's grandmother from 3 feet away
- Interesting and relevant: Present facts, provide insight and conclusions
- No typos: Spelling, consistent use of capitalization and template
- Parallel construction: Start with all verbs or nouns
- No inaccurate data: On the slide and in relation to others
- Parallel Construction: Bullets in a list should share a common structure. For example, all bullets could be verbs like crawl, walk, run. Or, the bullets could be all nouns like baker, butcher, candlestick maker. However, bullets are rarely just single words, they are typically phrases. The following example provides a bullet structure that is NOT parallel
    - Good Data Scientists should be proficient in the following areas:
        - a data scientist should know how to identify outliers
        - work with R or Python
        - explaining Natural Language Processing
        - execute SQL Code

    These bullets feel awkward. They don't match…they are not using parallel structure. The following bullets are constructed correctly:
    - Good Data Scientists should be proficient in the following areas:
        - identifying outliers

- working with R or Python
- explaining Natural Language Processing
- executing SQL Code

Each of these bullets has a verb-noun construct making them match in structure.

Example Storyboard

My team was working with a client in Financial Services. The client needed help in accelerating the delivery of an Enterprise Data Warehouse (EDW). Key to this delivery was the need to identify the attributes that would be stored in the EDW that would provide information needed for reporting across the enterprise.

The development of a story and slide deck often starts out with conversations and a whiteboard. The team sat down and had a conversation about the story they wanted to tell the client. Once we had agreed on the storyline, we sketched out the storyboard for the slide deck that would be used to convey that story.

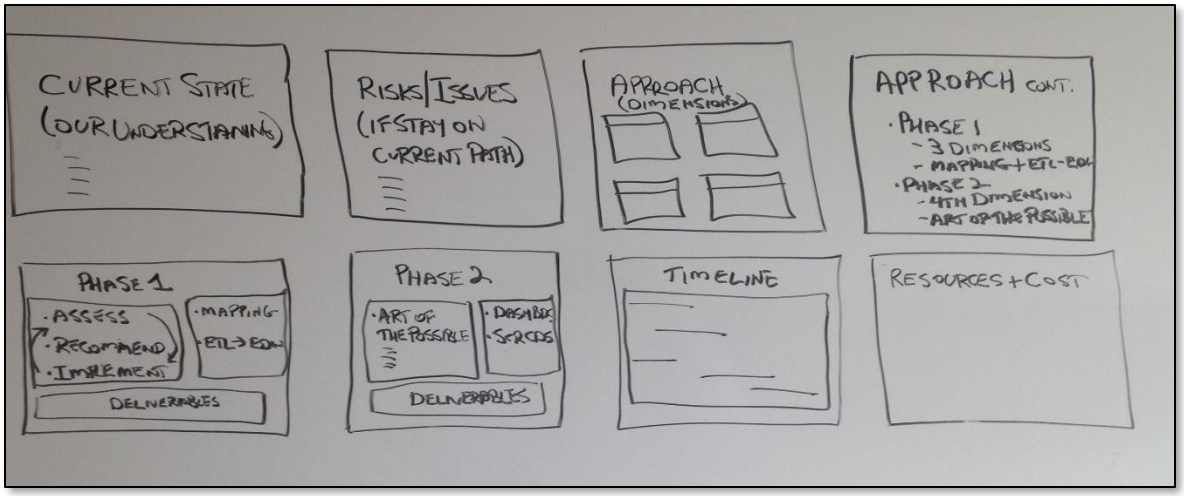
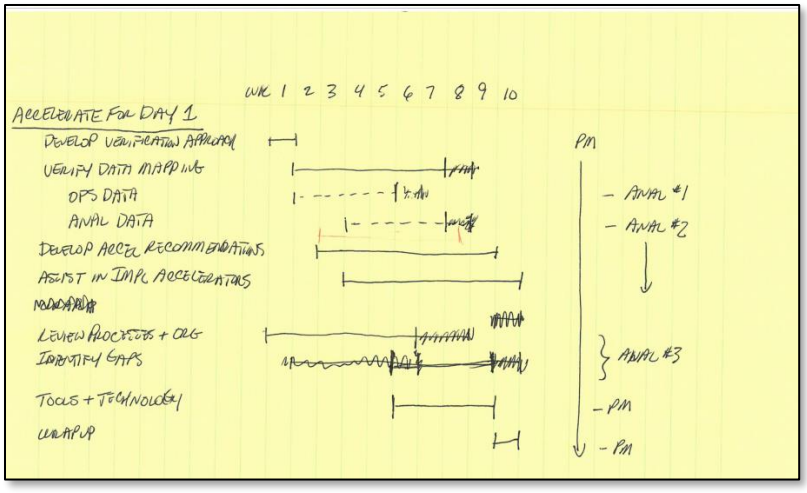
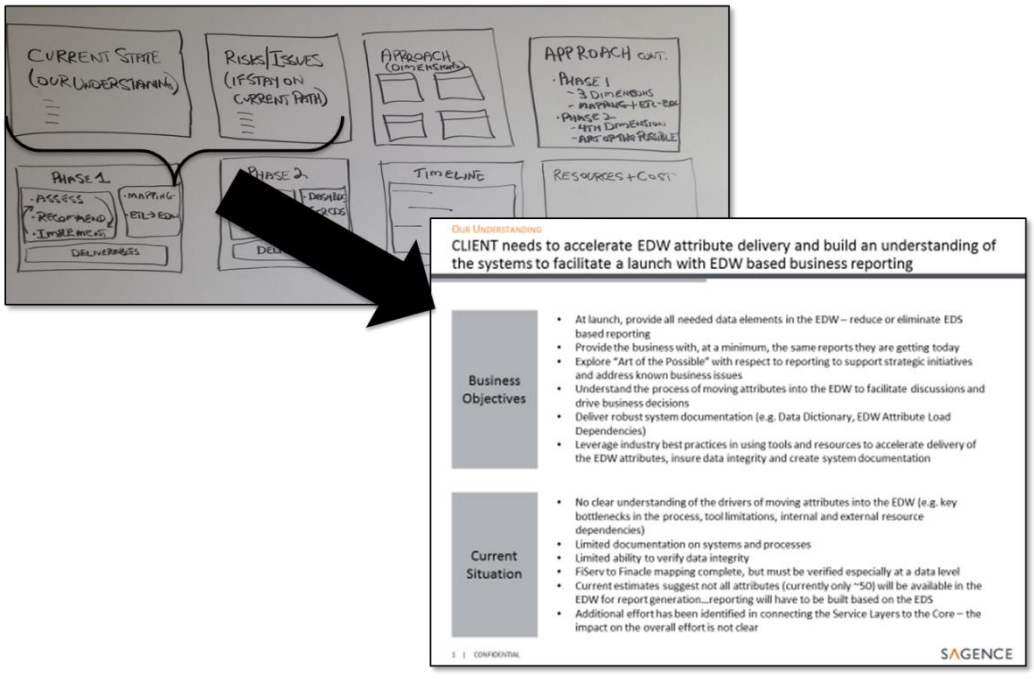


Photo of the storyboard created during the team meeting

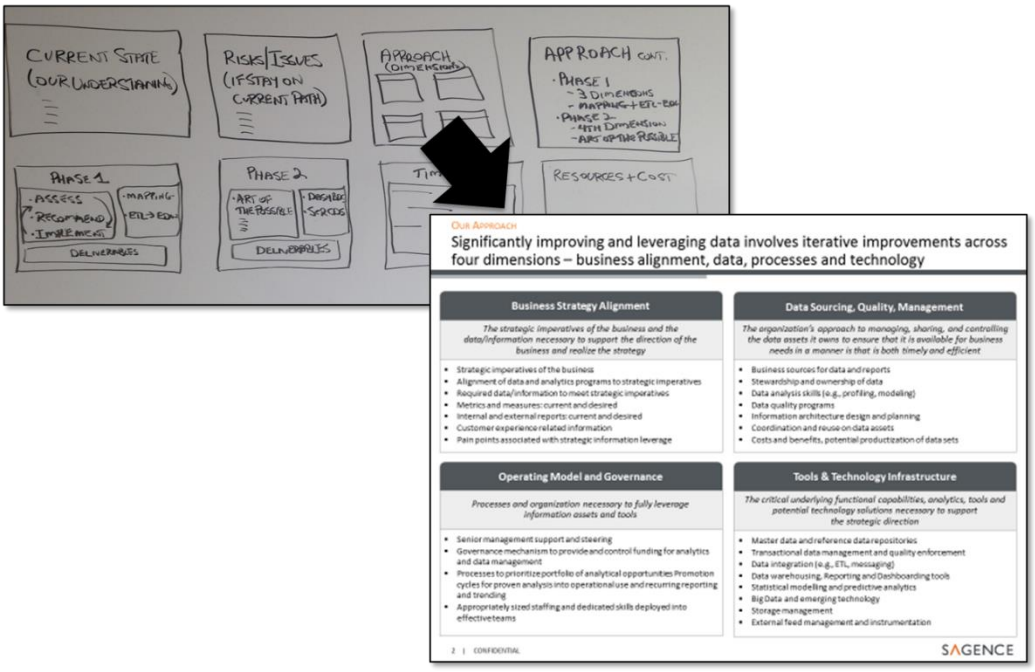
In a subsequent conversation more detail was worked out on the timeline and it was captured on a notepad.



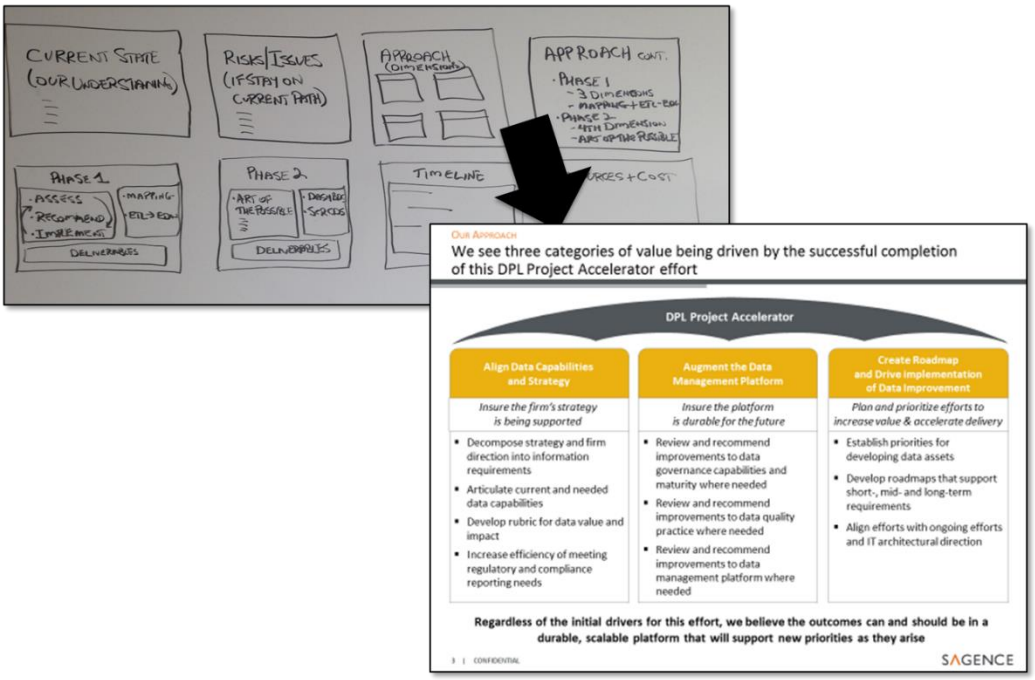
Subsequently the team worked on the deck. And, although the slides did not match exactly to the storyboard, the similarities are evident. The first two slides from the story board were condensed onto a single slide



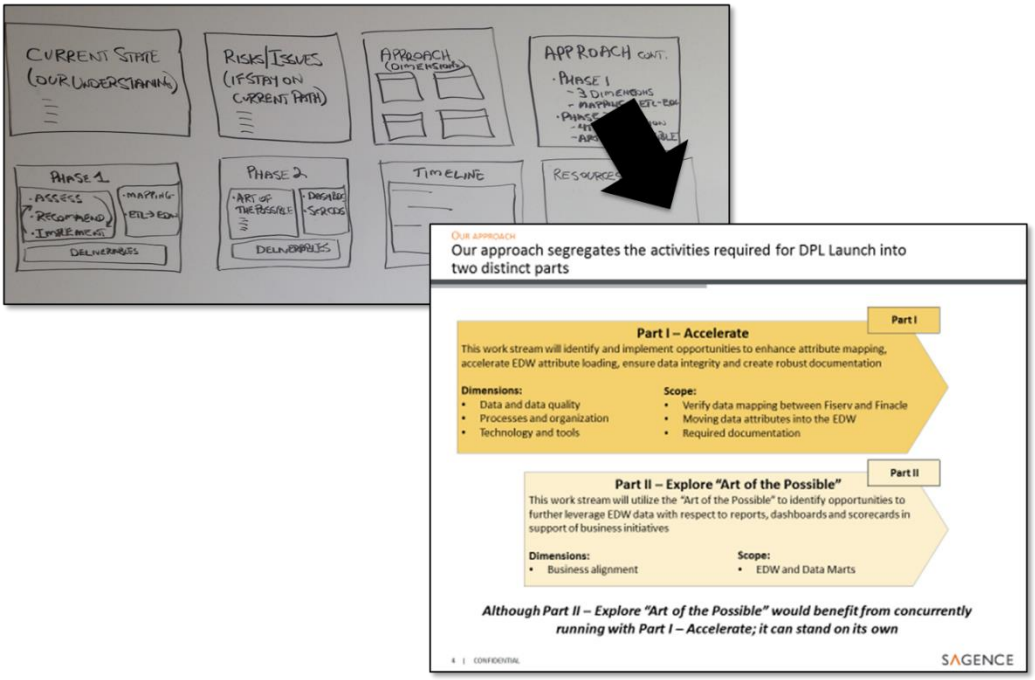
The third slide from the storyboard was created and was very close to the slide that was sketched on the storyboard.



The team realized that there was a slide that was needed in the story and it was added.



For the 4th slide in the storyboard, the content was the same, but a more visually appealing approach was used to convey the information.

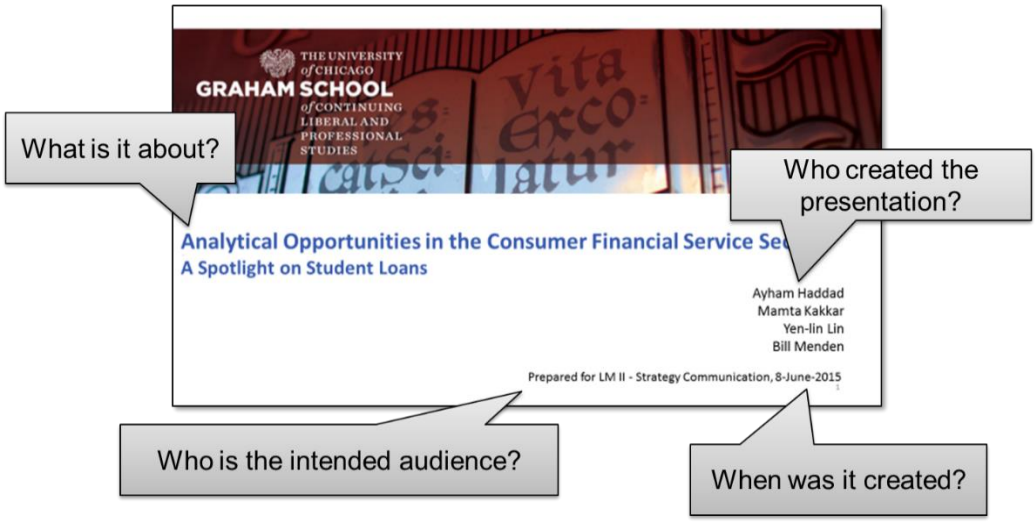


Structure and Style

Beyond the content, the structure and style of the deck is important.

Title Page

Tell the reader what's in the deck. The title page should include: date, presenters, audience and a title. Although not as relevant at the time of the presentation, it is valuable at any point in the future. The information on the title page provides the reader enough information to determine if the content what be appropriate for whatever reason they're looking through material…either paper or electronic form.



Date

The date provides a time context. If the reader is looking for cutting edge use of data science techniques, a deck that is ten years old is likely not as relevant as one that is only 30 days old.

Presenters

The group and/or list of presenters provides information on the capability of the people that put the information together. It can also provide a contact for the reader if that want to understand the information further.

Audience

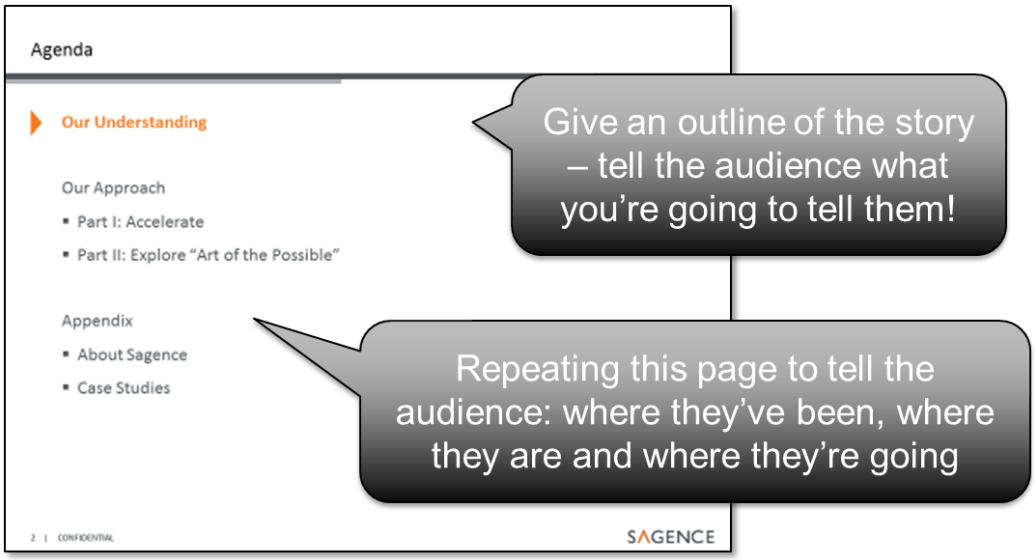
The target audience of the presentation provides information on the level of detail used to prepare the deck. Data science decks prepared for the sales team, data science team or CxOs all have a different context as we learned in the beginning of this section

Title

A well written title provides the best indication of the content contained in the deck. Unlike book titles, it doesn't need to be catchy, it just needs to inform

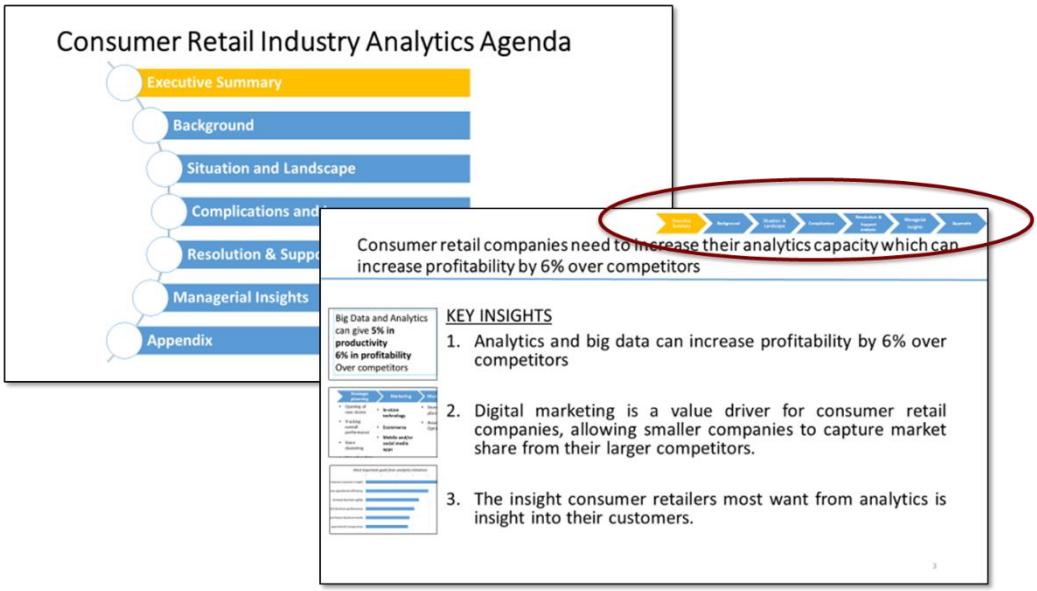
Agenda

Every deck should have an agenda, a structure to the story. Unless the story is short and the transitions clear, it can help to repeat the agenda page and highlight where you are in the story.

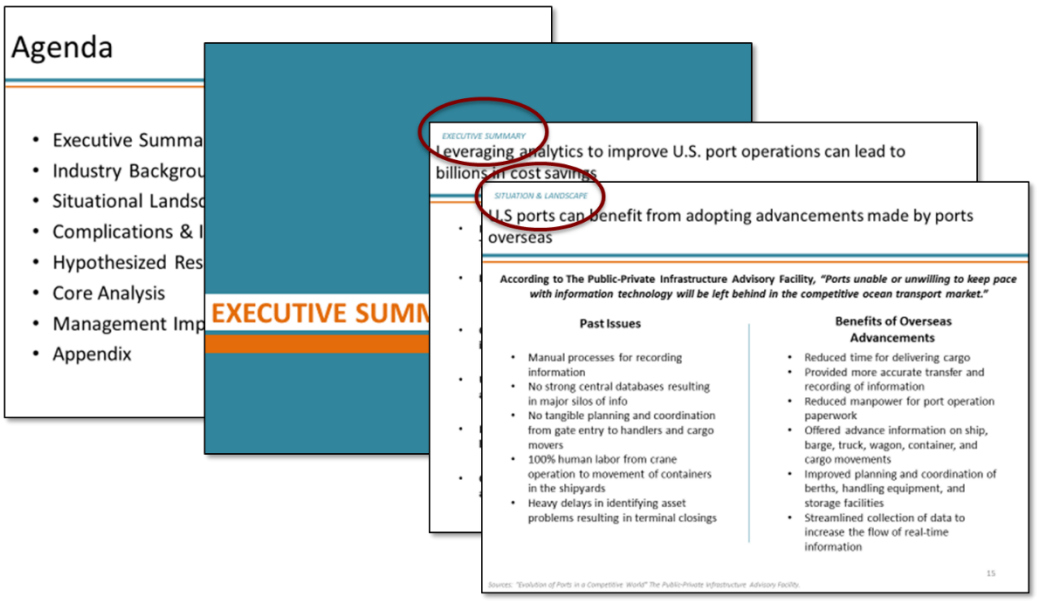


Breadcrumbs

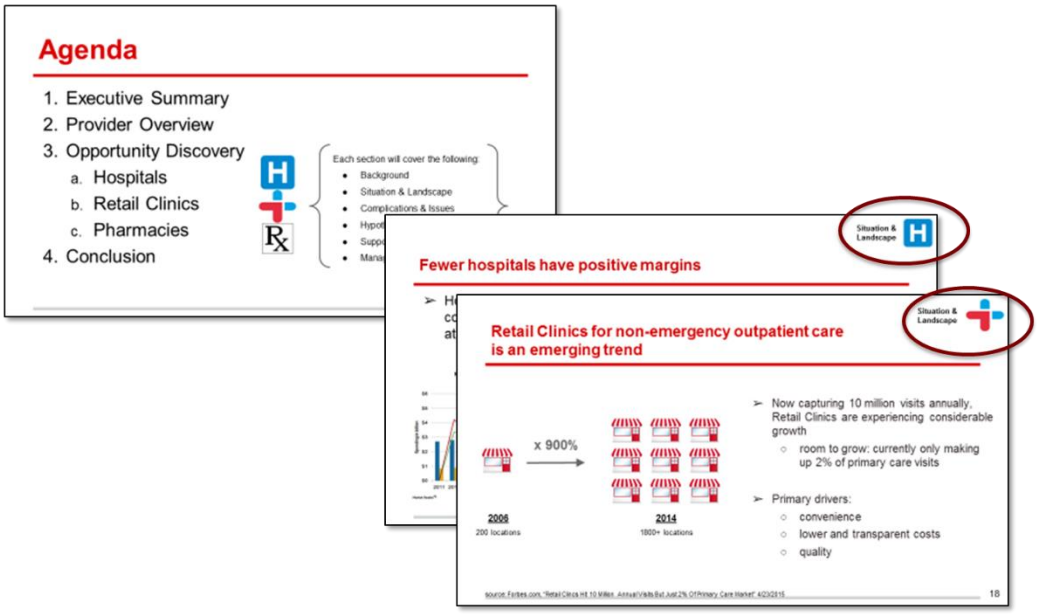
Breadcrumbs guide the reader, identifies where you are in the story utilizing a key on each page. ***The BREADCRUMBS should match the items in the agenda***. The breadcrumbs can be words, boxes or chevrons as seen in the figure below. In Microsoft PowerPoint, the chevrons are available as SmartArt. The current section of the deck is highlighted in the breadcrumbs by bolding text and/or using a highlight color.



Breadcrumbs can simply be words at the top of each page that refer back to the agenda



If there are relevant icons or graphics, they can be used as breadcrumbs



Although breadcrumbs are useful in guiding a reader through the presentation, they are not always needed. In short decks or high-level decks (e.g. TEDx presentation) they may not be needed. Ultimately the choice to include breadcrumbs

Secondary Breadcrumbs.

The concept of breadcrumbs can also apply to repeating lists in a storyline. For example, analytics opportunities will be identified, then they will be described and finally, one will be chosen from the list. Rather than using non-descriptive titles (e.g. Opportunity 1, Opportunity 2, …) or long descriptions, (e.g. Evaluation the potential for maintenance needs, segmenting the customer into addressable groups, …) consider using catchy short titles (e.g. #1. Predictive Maintenance, #2. Segmentation, …). These short titles should be used in each location. It will be easier for the reader or audience member to connect each opportunity across the pages and all readers or audience members will have an easy way to communicate about the different opportunities.

Page Numbers

Page Numbers are the most basic breadcrumbs. They provide the presenter and audience an easy reference to connect on the location in the deck. Make sure to include page numbers on every page. It is much easier for the audience to reference a page number rather than ask to go back a couple of pages. Many of us have seen the comedy of errors that occurs when you're navigating with the "no, not that one…back a couple…no, the other way!" – using a page number simplifies the navigation.

References & Sources

All data and examples should be referenced and sourced correctly. Having the references and sources on the page itself eliminates audience disruptions, "Where did this come from?" With the source or reference on the slide, audience members (or readers) likely will see it themselves, or the presenter can simply read to the audience member.

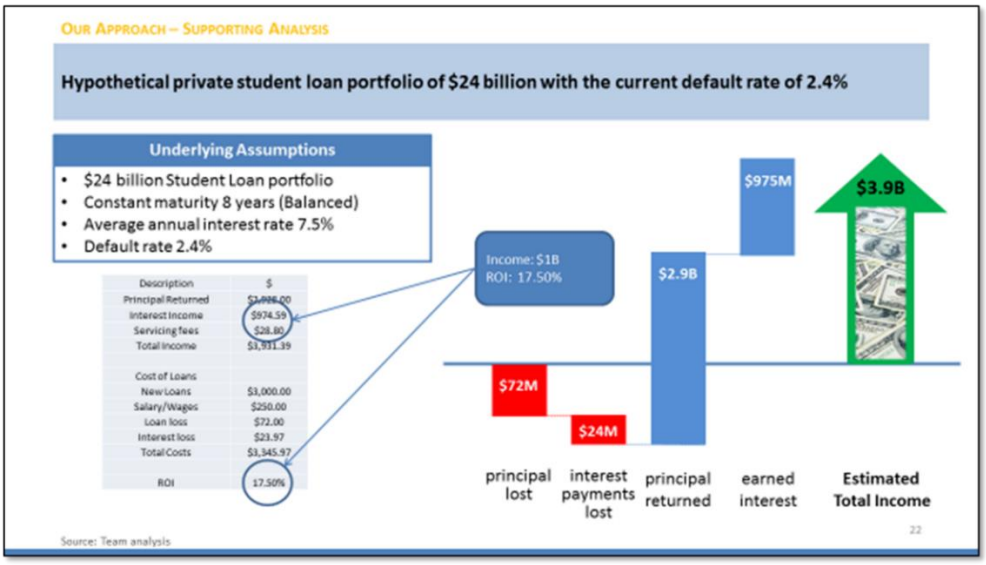
Almost every slide should have source and/or references. The source or reference should include information like the document title, author, date, and the source website, if available. The sources and reference should be consistently placed (e.g. lower left footer) on the slide and they should be consistently formatted (e.g. font style, font size, font color)

Frameworks & Models

Using a business framework or model, like value chains, Porter's five forces, or SWOT allow you to communicate your story in a structure that the audience, especially a business audience, is likely to understand.

You can also use a framework or model of your own construction, especially when you're going to use it several times in a deck. An example is in comparing options and using a Problem, Solution, Benefits framework to compare the different options.

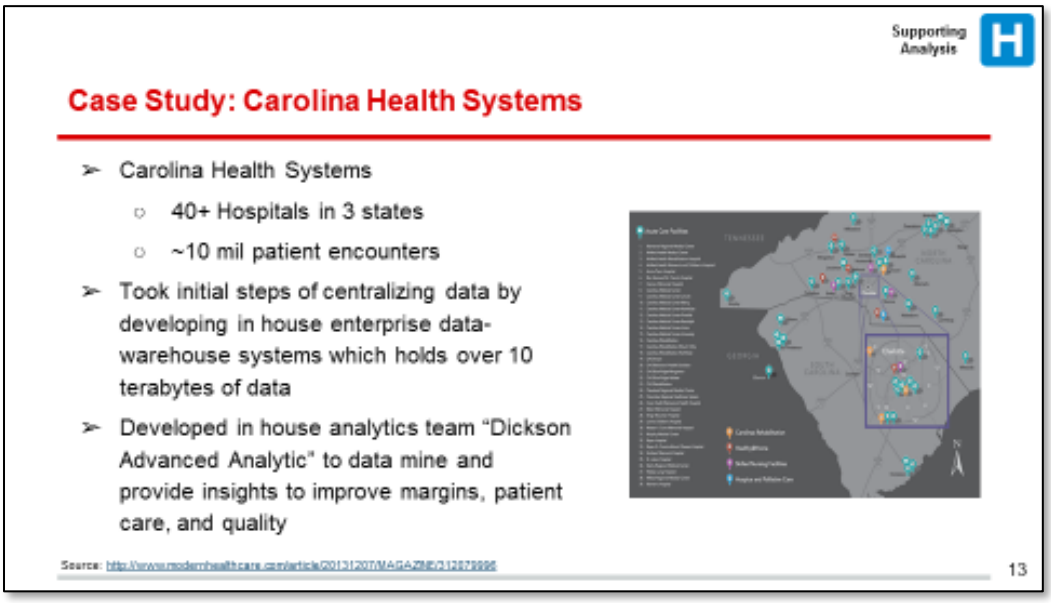
In this example, students built a framework to compare load portfolios based on different assumptions. It takes the reader a little time to understand the first example, but the subsequent slides are then more easily understood.



Examples, Cases, and Illustrations

Include examples, cases and illustrations when they are relevant, support the story and/or deepen the audience's understanding. These can be used to show what you expect to gain by leveraging the specific example or what you're going to avoid in a specific case study.





Visualizations

Use visualizations to clearly communicate information. Remember to include enough information, but no more – keep it simple. Visualization techniques convey the meaning without clutter. Here is some high level guidance on making your deck more visually appealing and easier to understand.

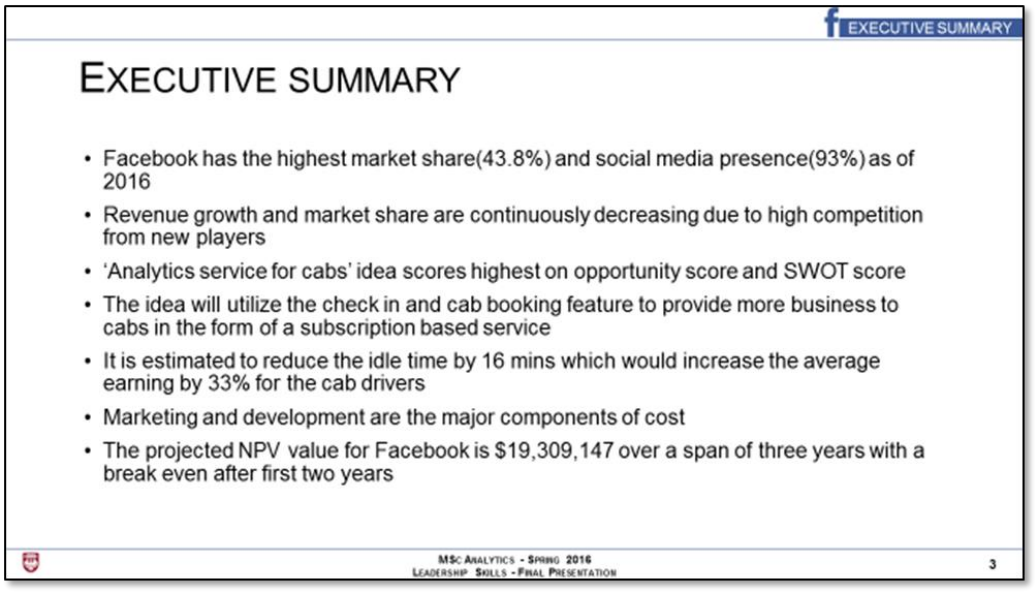
- Don't repeat words. Repeating patterns of words suggest the need to reorganize information on the slide, or across multiple slides.
- Use Fewer Words: Pick and choose your words carefully. Be precise and concise with the information on the slide. Heed the advice from the Mark Twain and Thomas Jefferson at the beginning of this module

- Use visuals or graphs rather than words or numbers! Consider the adage that a picture is worth a thousand words as a way to reduce clutter. Select the representation that most clearly communicates the meaning you desire.
- Highlight (bold, underline, heat map, circle) key words or numbers. If you must use many word or numbers, consider highlighting or calling out specific words or numbers to help the audience see the important information. A large table of numbers can be much more easily understood if a heat map is applied
- Use Legends. If you have any form of coloring or highlighting on a chart, diagram or table, make sure to setup a legend for the colors, highlighting, etc. Don't assume that the audience will understand your meaning…call it out specifically.
- Be careful, using elements such as boxes, circles or arrows consistently. Differences infer importance, "goodness" or rank order. If that is not intended, make the elements the same. If it is intended, make sure to include a legend to detail the differences.
- Consistently use fonts including typeface, size and color. Differences can infer unintended meaning.

NOTE: We will explore Visualizations in more detail in Module #

Introductions and Summaries

Most presentations follow a BLUF, or "Bottom-Line Up-Front" approach. For this approach an executive summary at the beginning of the deck, describes the key points that are going to be made in the storyline.



Another storyline approach, typically called "Common Discovery" does not include an Executive Summary at the beginning of the deck. It only has an agenda. The approach expects the audience to build an understanding of the story as it is delivered.

Every presentation should include a summary, or conclusion, of the important aspects of the storyline and identify key management implications at the end of the presentation.



The common storyline approach of "tell me what you're going to tell me, tell me, tell me what you told me" is based on BLUF with an Executive Summary (and agenda) at the beginning of the deck, the story, and a Conclusion at the end of deck.

Appendix

Appendices provide detail and additional information—both from a breadth and depth of information. Although the appendix isn't part of the story, the slides in the appendix still should be well structured with storyline like titles and vertical logic.

The appendix should include more information on slides that weren't deemed necessary for the core story. For example, the story may include a slide with one line summaries of sales by geography. In the appendix a detailed slide for each geography could be included. If the CxO has questions about specific details, there's a slide that you can bring up.

The appendix can also include parallel information that was explored, but not considered necessary for the main story / presentation. For example, if ten opportunities were considered and three opportunities were detailed in the main deck. In the appendix, information on the other seven opportunities could be included to show the work. If the CxO references an opportunity that you did not include in the main deck, but that you did consider, you can go to that slide in the appendix to show the details and explain why it didn't make the cut.

What is interesting, especially for CxO related decks, the appendix in many cases is much longer than the core deck. In my experience, the storyline of the deck is 10 – 15 slides long and the appendix contains well over one hundred pages.

Summary

This summarizes the information needed to communicate using a slide deck. Ultimately the number of slides, the level of detail and the level of sophistication is dependent on the context of the communication.

Content

Context. Understand the situation clearly and tailor you document to the specific situation

Story. Take key objectives and translate them into a logical flow; this is often called the Storyline or Horizontal Logic: titles from each page can be compiled with the resulting text being the "story"

Details. Breaking the storyline into simple and effective modules with details, typically the slide Vertical Logic: slide bodies unambiguously support headlines…the story

Structure and Style

Title Page. Tell the reader what's in the deck. Should include: clear title, date, presenters, audience

Agenda. Every deck should have an agenda-a structure to the story.

Breadcrumbs. Breadcrumbs guide the reader, identifies where you are in the story

Page Numbers. Page Numbers are the most basic bread crumbs

References & Sources. All data and examples should be referenced and sourced correctly

Frameworks & Models. Describes information clearly & completely

Examples, cases and illustrations. Include when they are relevant, support the story and/or deepen understanding

Visualizations. Use visualizations to clearly communicate information. Enough information, but no more – keep it simple

Introduction and Summaries. Presentations should include a summary of important aspects of the approach and identify key management implications

Appendix. Appendices provide detail and additional information—breadth and depth; Appendices should be well structured

Additional Resources:

- Build Great Presentations, Mattan Griffel @ Slideshare http://www.slideshare.net/mattangriffel/building-great-presentations-14607985/56-Slides_from_Garr_Reynolds_Presentation
- Top Ten Slide Tips, Garr Reynolds http://www.garrreynolds.com/preso-tips/design/
- How can I make my PowerPoint presentations Amazing, Lifehacker, Melanie Pinola http://lifehacker.com/how-can-i-make-my-powerpoint-presentations-amazing-507552122
- The Minto Pyramid Principle http://www.barbaraminto.com